

AI FOR EAST AFRICAN COMMUNITY 2026



**SCIENCE
TECHNOLOGY
AND
INNOVATION
CONFERENCE**



**EAST AFRICAN SCIENCE &
TECHNOLOGY COMMISSION
EASTECO**



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4TH EAC REGIONAL SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY AND INNOVATION CONFERENCE REPORT

THEME:

**Harnessing Artificial Intelligence
for a Resilient, Inclusive
and Innovative
East Africa**

30 MARCH - 1 APRIL 2026

KIGALI CONVENTION CENTRE, RWANDA

www.sti.easteco.org

Side Event 3: Leveraging Responsible AI for Climate Resilience in Africa: Policy Readiness, Capacity Building, and Action Pathways

Session Overview

This side event focused on advancing human-centred and ethical AI adoption for climate resilience in Africa, with emphasis on policy readiness, capacity building, and actionable solutions. Led by the Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), the session brought together stakeholders from research, policy, and practice to examine gaps in AI skills, institutional frameworks, and implementation. Key discussions highlighted the ARIN fellowship program, mapping of AI initiatives, and barriers such as funding constraints, gender disparities, and limited infrastructure. Participants emphasized the importance of translating research into practical applications, particularly in agriculture and community resilience. The session concluded with strong calls for collaboration, inclusive participation, and integration of indigenous knowledge and ethical foresight in AI development.

Speaker: Humphrey Agevi

Session Moderator: EAC AI Alliance

Session Rapporteur: Dr. Marie Chantal Cyulinyana

Key Presentations:

Session 1: Opening and Context Setting

The presenter introduced ARIN as a pan-African think tank operating in 36 countries, focusing on evidence generation and policy influence. He presented the “AI for Climate Resilience” project, emphasizing Africa’s vulnerability to climate change despite low emissions and the need for AI-driven adaptive solutions.

Session 2: Policy and Regulatory Readiness

The presentation highlighted emerging AI strategies across Africa, including efforts in countries like Kenya and Egypt. However, gaps remain in policy implementation, infrastructure, and institutional readiness. Participants stressed the importance of integrating AI into national climate adaptation plans while avoiding over-regulation that could hinder innovation.

Session 3: Capacity Building for Responsible AI

Findings from ARIN’s scoping and capacity assessment revealed limited AI programs, skills shortages, gender disparities, and weak institutional support. The ARIN AI Fellowship program was presented, with 379 applicants and 100 selected fellows. Discussions emphasized the need for inclusive training, mentorship, and practical learning approaches.

Session 4: Applied AI for Anticipatory Action and Humanitarian Resilience

Discussions focused on translating AI research into practical applications, particularly in agriculture and community resilience (e.g., market price prediction tools). Participants emphasized engaging telecom companies for providing data and infrastructure, and ensuring solutions are accessible to non-academic users and local communities.

Session 5: Way Forward and Action Pathways

Participants identified key priorities including strengthening partnerships, promoting innovation hubs, protecting intellectual property, and integrating indigenous knowledge into AI systems.

Ethical foresight, gender inclusion, and community engagement were highlighted as critical for sustainable AI adoption.

KEY POINTS AND EMERGING ISSUES

The recommendations from the session emphasise the importance of strengthening awareness, inclusivity, and practical support mechanisms to deepen participation in the region's AI and research ecosystem. A key priority is for the Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN) to expand its visibility across all East African Community (EAC) countries and provide clearer guidance on how individuals and institutions can engage—particularly through fellowship programmes and alliance membership. This is intended to broaden participation and ensure that opportunities are accessible to a wider range of stakeholders.

Participants also highlighted the need to strengthen innovation ecosystems by ensuring that organised competitions are supported by robust intellectual property protection frameworks. This would help safeguard ideas, encourage participation, and build confidence among innovators. At the same time, there was a strong call to improve linkages between researchers and policymakers, ensuring that research outputs—especially in AI—are translated into actionable policies and real-world solutions.

Inclusivity was a major theme, with recommendations to increase targeted outreach to women and other underrepresented groups in order to address existing disparities in access to research funding and opportunities. Complementing this, the development of community-level innovation hubs was proposed as a way to support grassroots innovators, foster local solutions, and integrate indigenous knowledge systems into broader innovation processes.

The session also emphasised the strategic role of the private sector, particularly telecommunications companies, in providing the data, infrastructure, and connectivity needed to scale AI solutions. In parallel, there was a call to embed ethical foresight and responsible AI principles into both academic curricula and project design, ensuring that innovation is guided by strong ethical considerations from the outset.

Finally, participants stressed the need to mobilise resources and expand partnerships to scale AI-driven climate resilience initiatives. This reflects a growing recognition of AI's potential to address pressing environmental challenges, provided that sufficient investment and collaboration are in place to support implementation at scale.

